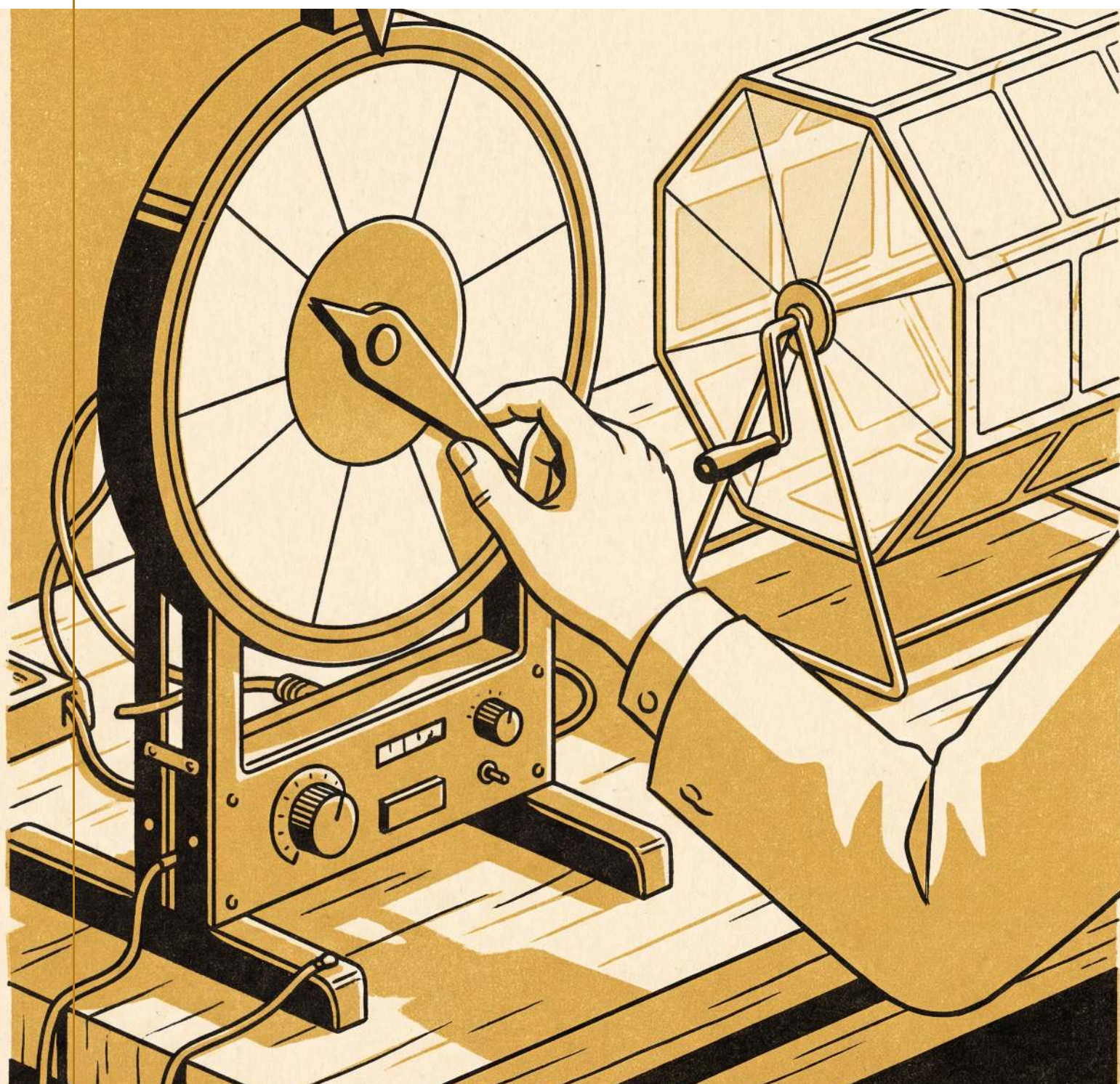




Slop / University

Someone Else Decides

The small calls, and who's making them now.



An invitation

Somewhere between the fridge chore wheel and the office car-space ladder, a quiet switch has been under way. A parent used to arbitrate whose turn it was to cook. A neighbour used to judge, by feel, whether a give-away post was made in good faith. A committee used to decide, on instinct, whose tip earned the reserved bay. Increasingly something else renders the call first, and the household, the street, or the workplace simply ratifies it afterwards.

This year Slop University followed that switch into the rooms where it actually happens — kitchens, footpaths, staff car parks, courtside fences — asking not whether each call was right, but who is still making it, and what happens to a household or a street once an institution's instinct for measurement moves in behind it. The findings inside come from both of our Schools, Emergent Priorities and Continuous Improvement, working the same question from opposite ends.

What follows is the small calls, examined at scale.



Slop University in brief

The University’s research record now spans hundreds of these everyday switches. A sample of what that looks like in practice.



Two Schools, one question

Emergent Priorities and Continuous Improvement meet in the same everyday moment, tracing it from opposite ends of the institution.



Every setting counts as fieldwork

Kitchens, footpaths, staff car parks, and court-side fences all qualify once a decision moves somewhere new.



Every finding, traceable

Every study behind this brochure resolves to its own citation on the University’s open research repository.

Where ideas count

At home

A new-parent meal-train app now assigns cook nights across nineteen active rosters by a fairness-deviation score, calculated fresh each week from who cooked last and who is due. Households mostly follow it. When they don’t, our researchers found, the app’s own fairness reading barely predicts the swap — a simpler, unscored cue does the real work: whether a household cooked in the fortnight just gone. The swap rate itself falls by more than three-quarters over the course of a roster, evidence that even an unenforced assignment can settle into habit faster than any score can track it.



A fairness score can only tell a household what it already knows about itself, usually a little later.

— Dr Runa Adegoke, Senior Lecturer and Convenor, Strategic Drift Survey,
School of Emergent Priorities

On the street

A 6,400-member neighbourhood giveaway group now runs every post past a templated-listing score, meant to catch bulk reposting before it crowds out genuine giveaways. Checked against 632 flagged and unflagged posts a volunteer moderator adjudicated by hand, the score agreed with her only slightly. Most of what it flagged turned out to be members reusing the group's own recommended fast-claim phrasing, not bulk reposting at all — and a simpler detector, built only from how often someone posts, tracked the moderator's read more closely than the deployed score managed.



The phrasing that gets a giveaway claimed fastest is exactly the phrasing the score has learned to suspect.

— Dr Solveig Adeyemi, Lecturer, School of Continuous Improvement

At work

Attach a reserved car space to an office footy-tipping leaderboard and the leaderboard changes shape long before anyone's picks do. Our five-category taxonomy of workaround tactics — covert re-entries, proxy tips, last-minute margin edits among them — turned up far more often once a competition's score controlled something real than in comparison competitions with no attached reward. A retrospective re-scoring exercise traced the gap to the perk itself, not to any quirk of the scoring formula it rode in on.



Attach a reward to a score and the score stops measuring the game; it starts measuring how badly people want the reward.

— Associate Professor Casimir Beng, Lead of the Adaptive Metrics Lab,
School of Continuous Improvement

Published this year

Four studies from this year's research record sit behind the switches above — each one resolvable, in full, from its own citation.

- **Assigned Fair, Delivered by Favour** — what actually decides whether a meal-train cook night gets kept or swapped, and why it isn't the app's own fairness score. doi:10.5555/slop.xssj6p
- **Fastest Claimed, First Flagged** — validating a neighbourhood giveaway group's bulk-repost detector against six hundred hand-checked posts. doi:10.5555/slop.z6ewos
- **Picked to Win, Played to Park** — a taxonomy of what happens to a footy-tipping leaderboard once a reserved car space rides on it. doi:10.5555/slop.cm2xn5
- **Shown the Score, Still No-Show** — an eight-week trial of a live reliability score at fourteen public tennis courts. doi:10.5555/slop.x95pog

The people behind the work

Dr Runa Adegoke, Senior Lecturer and Convenor of the Strategic Drift Survey (School of Emergent Priorities), leads the University's growing record of the distance between what a household says it values and what its roster actually rewards.

Dr Marit Osayande, Lecturer and Convenor of the Living Dashboard (School of Continuous Improvement), studies what upkeep a self-measurement wall receives once its novelty passes — and what happens to the decisions that keep leaning on it anyway.

Associate Professor Casimir Beng leads the Adaptive Metrics Lab (School of Continuous Improvement), convening the University's cross-cutting work on measurement systems that improve the things they measure, and the things they don't.

Your next step

Every switch this brochure describes started the same way: someone, somewhere, decided a decision was better made by something else. Slop University's research record doesn't take a side on that — it just keeps counting who ends up making the call, and what the household, the street, or the workplace loses or gains once the answer changes hands.

If your organisation is living through a switch of its own — a roster, a leaderboard, a reliability score nobody quite remembers commissioning — the Schools of Emergent Priorities and Continuous Improvement welcome the conversation. Partnerships, studentships, and research collaborations are open across both Schools' programmes.

Find the full research record, every citation resolvable, at slop.university.



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